



Photograph S Bhojwani

Each month *Digit* will carry a caption for a photo. Come up with something funnier, and beat the *Digit* team at their own game! Entries accepted by the 20th of this month.

Beat That!

Digit Caption

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Last Month's Winner!

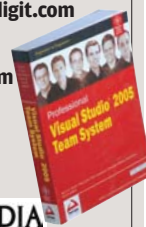
Sumit Banerjee,
Kolkata, West Bengal

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WILEY-INDIA

rules for conduction of international flights, issues the specifications for RFID-enabled biometric passports.

Security experts from all over have been saying for a while now that e-passports aren't safe. First, experts on the subject in the EU said the concept of the e-passport was "poorly conceived," and a week later, a chink in the armour of the e-passport was reported by *The Guardian* in the UK: the data on the RFID chip was easily accessible, it turned out.

Later last year, Lukas Grunwald, a German security researcher from consulting firm DN-Systems, demonstrated in collaboration with another researcher that e-passports carrying RFID chips could easily be cloned—in five minutes, at that—using an RFID reader.

Grunwald has now found another flaw. The RFID chip embedded in the passport is meant to thwart document forgery; Grunwald cloned a passport's RFID chip, manipulated the image file containing the photo, and

then used the altered chip to break the RFID reader that is currently used.

It has been pointed out, though, that Grunwald used a German passport with a fingerprint biometrics; his exploit would not hold in the case of other countries' biometric passports. Paul Proctor from Gartner's technology research group has commented that there is only a small probability of the same exploit being found in other e-passport systems, but that if one is found, it might have high impact. Still, the probability is there, and we'll be watching for developments. As of now, the biggest issue is that there exist no uniform biometric technologies and specifications for e-passports. India is completely out of the picture here, though Pakistan has been issuing machine-readable passports since October 2004!

We cannot go into the issues behind the need for e-passports in the first place—we'd have to talk about terrorism and such. But there are lessons to be

learnt: standards and international cooperation are a necessity if the whole e-passport thing is to take off worldwide; that the rollout of a technology in as important a field as citizen safety should not be rushed; that as our dependence on technology increases, even if we live with the fact, responsible bodies should be, well, responsible.

SUIT UP!

PowerPoint An Essential Skill

We've all made / laughed at / heard jokes about how the fancy corporate types live their lives by the spreadsheet and the PPT—and they do, too. PowerPoint skills are highly appreciated at the workplace—not only for effective communication, but (if used wisely) to keep people interested enough not to drop dead with boredom.

And now, the University of Chicago has finally bowed to the inevitable, decreeing that PowerPoint skills will figure in the criteria for their selection of potential B-school students.

Starting this year, hopeful candidates will be required to submit four pages of PowerPoint (or similar) slides with their applications. The goal, apparently, is to be able to judge students on creativity—something not entirely possible through their test scores, application essays or even letters of recommendation. The tactic, the university says, will help them attract truly creative students—the rare breed that can actually create an interesting presentation.

Microsoft estimates that the world is subjected to 30 million presentations a day—most, as we're sure you've noticed, highly unpleasant viewing. Oh, the stories... we've seen execs who think that using Comic Sans MS can magically "lighten the mood" of a presentation, or